SCAFOLDING SAFETY

Safety is a top concern when working at height. Alarmingly, scaffolding-related incidents lead to approximately 4,500 injuries annually. Accidents frequently cause physical injuries and also lead to serious financial issues. This includes lost workdays costing an estimated $90 million, potential fines, and higher insurance premiums.

Fortunately, there are many ways for companies to protect their employees from these preventable accidents. The following scaffolding safety tips will help reduce the risks of an accident when working at heights

1. Use Proper Safety Equipment

Personal protective equipment (PPE) is necessary when working in any industrial or construction setting, especially at height. Wearing a hard hat on scaffolds is crucial to protect against injuries from falling objects. Non-slip footgear and especially proper fall arrest equipment are also essential when working on platforms.

Incorporating hand-protecting gloves and tool-tether lanyards is essential to further enhance working-at-heights safety. Slip-resistant gloves improve tool grip, making workers less likely to drop them.

Tool tethering lanyards also securely attach tools to workers, preventing falls that could endanger others working below. This combination of fall protection equipment boosts safety and improves operational efficiency.

2. Be Aware of Load Limits

Manufacturers design scaffolding equipment with specific load-bearing capacities and load limits in mind. Your workers could be at serious risk of injury if you place excessive loads on scaffolding structures greater than the intended design capacity. Scaffold platforms might break, fail or collapse —causing potentially severe injuries for workers on or near the scaffolding. Fortunately, scaffolding components are designed with a 4 to 1 safety factor providing a significant capacity safety cushion, but it is always good to know what your scaffold structure load capacity actually is before putting concentrated loads on the decks.

3. Know Relevant Regulations and Standards

Every industry has its own specific regulations and standards. Scaffolding regulations are generally governed by Federal OSHA for different Industry classifications and specific customer sites may also have project standards over and above OSHA, so research the specific OSHA, Industry and customer site requirements before constructing any platforms.

Building and using scaffold structures that are installed according to applicable standards and regulations can prevent accidents, employee risks and, at the very least, avoid liability for not meet necessary standards. In addition, as required in the Competent Person inspection requirement for all scaffolding users, your workers should be trained to recognize and minimize the risks and hazards of whatever type of scaffolding you're using on your project.

4. Inspect Scaffolding Materials

Before setting up your work platforms, you must inspect all your materials beforehand. Make sure none of the parts have defects or damage that could compromise the structural integrity of your scaffolds. Mismatching components can pose a significant scaffolding hazard and lead to structural failure.

5. Build Properly

Follow the instructions provided by the manufacturer when building your scaffold. Check the types of bracing, fasteners and anchor requirements to ensure that you're erecting the scaffold according to the manufacturer's instructions. Do not take shortcuts or improvise your own design.

You also want to ensure the work area is entirely safe when building your scaffold. A level ground surface works best (if possible), but with the right components, scaffolding can be safely built on sloped terrain. If working near power lines, certain safety guidelines apply, but at a minimum you must stay 10-feet or more from the power lines. Always consult a qualified scaffolding expert when working near power lines. In addition, regulations require a Competent Builder Person to be present and supervise scaffolding erection and dismantle work. A competent person is someone who has received OSHA-approved training, scaffolding

manufacturer equipment training, and has the accompanying title and authority assigned by their company.

Be sure to check for the following:

- Leg braces should be correctly installed on the frame of the scaffold.
- The standards, planks, decks and scaffold structure are **"level, plum and square"** that creates a stable and safe scaffold structure for workers to do work on.
- Installers must rigidly install decks, planks, brackets, toeboards, and tubes plus ensure all connections are tightly secured.
- Mud sills and base plates should be the correct size and installed rigidly to the scaffold feet and frame.

- As per OSHA regulations, there should be at least 10 feet of clearance between electrical hazards and scaffolds. You'll need to de-energize the line or have the power company wrap it if the distance is less than 10 feet.

6. Inspect the Site and Equipment—Again

The need for inspections doesn't go away after you've erected the scaffolding. Check the area regularly for hazards, defects, debris, or other factors that could cause a problem.

Competent User Person's conduct inspections at the start of each workday to confirm the area is hazard-free for that shift. Consider using scaffolding safety check-lists to ensure all safety elements are confirmed every day.

7. Keep Vehicles and Heavy Equipment Clear

Always keep vehicles and heavy equipment clear of the scaffold base. Setting up barriers can keep the whole structure from toppling. In situations when it's necessary to have heavy equipment nearby. make sure the equipment has clearance.

8. Stay Organized

"Good housekeeping" isn't just a magazine in the supermarket checkout line. Maintaining cleanliness and order on scaffolds is crucial for safety. Ensuring the scaffolding is free from tools, debris, excess scaffolding planks, or trash is essential.

These items can create tripping hazards or add undue stress to the scaffold structure, potentially leading to a collapse. Regularly schedule clean-up sessions and encourage workers to tidy their working areas to prevent these risks.

9. Mind the Weather

You want to ensure the conditions are safe when working at height. Working during harsh weather conditions or other environmental hazards can increase the risk of serious injury. For instance, high winds could risk injury to those working on the scaffold. If a storm has brought down a power line, that could also create a scaffolding hazard.

In addition to wind, weather conditions like heavy rain, lightning, snow, and ice pose significant risks to scaffold safety. OSHA guidelines advise against climbing, using, or erecting scaffolds.

Workers should know these hazards and avoid using the scaffold during weather events. Monitoring forecasts and enforcing weather safety rules ensures a hazard-free workplace.

Learn how Scaffolding Solutions mitigated high wind concerns when installing scaffolding on an aviation hangar.

10. Be Fully Licensed

Working with fully licensed staff and contractors helps prevent injuries. This ensures everyone on site understands proper scaffolding practices. Obtaining a license requires education, training time, and hands-on experience. This rigorous preparation enables your team to perform their duties competently and safely.

11. Climb Responsibly

Scaffold safety requires careful attention to climbing practices. Workers must maintain three points of contact with the scaffold at all times—either two hands and one foot, or one hand and two feet.

Scaffold erectors can climb vertical and horizontal bars during assembly or disassembly if they securely tie themselves off. All other users should stick to ladders, ramps, or stair towers for climbing.

12. Scaffolding Safety Tags

Scaffolding tags help identify whether or not a scaffold is safe to use. A competent person (as defined by OSHA) must inspect and tag the scaffold structure. There are three different types of scaffolding tags:

Green scaffold tags—If you see a green tag on a scaffold, a competent person has inspected it and verified it is safe for use. Each access point should have a green tag after the completed initial inspection.

Yellow scaffold tags—Yellow tags indicate that scaffolds have undergone modifications to their structure or components to fulfill particular work

requirements. However, these changes have the potential to introduce new hazards or risks. The yellow tags outline special safety precautions or usage guidelines that all users must follow.

Red scaffold tags—If you see a red tag, it means there is danger and the scaffold is unsafe for use. Workers often use these tags when they're erecting or dismantling the scaffold.

13. Ground Fault Circuit Interrupters (GFCI)

Use Ground Fault Circuit Interrupters (GFCIs) for all electrical tools used on scaffolds. GFCIs greatly reduce the chance of electric shock. Requiring slip-resistant gloves and tool lanyards as personal protective equipment also improves safety. Attaching tools prevents them from falling and injuring those below.

14. Causes of Damage

Understanding what causes damage to scaffolding is crucial for maintaining a safe work environment. Workers can damage scaffolding by forcibly hitting it during manual labor or through contact with vehicles/motorized equipment. Exceeding the structure's maximum load capacity can also compromise its integrity.

Environmental elements like rust due to oxidation can weaken the scaffold's structure. Conducting regular inspections and not exceeding weight limits helps minimize these hazards and ensures the scaffolds remain safe and functional.

Scaffolding integrity is vulnerable to more than just damage from excessive weight. It can also suffer damage from forceful impacts, like manual labor or motorized equipment. Environmental elements, such as rust, can weaken the structure over time. Regular inspections for these types of wear and tear are crucial to maintain scaffolding safety.

15. Distance for Heavy Equipment

Setting a safe distance between scaffolding and heavy equipment is essential to prevent accidents. As a guideline, keep a minimum distance of at least 10 feet away from all heavy machinery.

For larger vehicles and their greater swinging/reaching range, set up an exclusion zone 20 feet away or more. Maintaining this protective buffer prevents hazardous collisions that could compromise the scaffolding and endanger workers.

16. Climbing Safety Instructions

Safe climbing practices are essential for scaffold safety. All scaffold users must adhere to designated climbing methods to prevent falls and injuries. The only permissible ways to ascend and descend scaffolding are through ladders, ramps, or stair towers. This ensures maximum safety and compliance with established safety standards.

Scaffold erectors have specific guidelines for climbing during the erection or dismantling of the scaffold. They can climb vertical legs and horizontal bars, but only in these circumstances and while adequately tied off. This precaution is necessary for their safety and the scaffold's structural integrity.

All other workers should only use approved climbing components. They should not climb cross braces, diagonals, bars, vertical legs, guardrails, or other non-designated parts.

Adhering to these protocols is vital for maintaining a safe work environment and minimizing the risk of accidents. By restricting climbing to designated areas and methods, the safety of all workers involved with the scaffold is more assured.

17. Regularly Review Scaffolding Safety Updates

Staying up-to-date with the latest safety standards and practices is a continuous responsibility. Regularly reviewing evolving safety standards and equipment with all personnel creates a culture of constant learning.

For example, repeatedly referencing OSHA's scaffolding safety guidelines will keep you up-to-date on the latest federal regulations. Bookmark their eTool page and have your designated competent person review it regularly for changes.

Prevent Hazards and Accidents With These Scaffold Safety Rules

Training staff to recognize scaffolding hazards and follow safety measures significantly reduces accidents and liability. Providing them with easy access to tools and personal protective equipment for further accident prevention is vital.

At Scaffolding Solutions, we are committed to scaffold safety. Our experienced team stays current on the latest standards and regulations for compliance. Our comprehensive training equips every crew member with the skills to erect scaffolding and identify potential hazards safely.

Click below to request a free quote for your upcoming scaffolding project. Our safety-focused services provide reliable scaffolding installations to keep your job site productive and accident-free.

Safety is always a top priority when working at tall heights. Scaffolding can present numerous hazards, especially if it isn't properly put together or if specific safety protocols aren't followed.

Companies that follow the safety guidelines detailed below should prevent most accidents and injuries resulting from working at certain heights.

Common Scaffolding Hazards

Some of the most common scaffolding hazards include the following:

Scaffold collapses

An incorrectly built scaffold runs a risk of collapse. In addition, carelessness with heavy equipment or materials may cause damage to the supports, overload the scaffold, or otherwise lead to a collapse.

Falling from scaffold

Poor construction without proper guards or failure to use adequate fall arrest equipment could lead to injuries from falls. Typically, any scaffold over ten feet from the ground needs some form of protection from falls.

Struck by falling objects

Items dropped from scaffolds could injure those on lower platforms or the ground. Installing proper toe boards or barricades can prevent injury from falling objects.

Electrocution

Scaffolds built near power lines put workers at risk of electric shock. OSHA regulations require a minimum of ten feet clearance between scaffolds and electrical hazards. If the distance is less than ten feet, the line needs to be shut off.

General Scaffolding Safety Tips

With the most common hazards in mind, we can take a look at the types of safety standards employees and managers should generally follow.

Know local regulations

First off, it's important to be familiar with local regulations and laws. Each state and city has its own laws governing scaffold safety, and OSHA itself has a set of universal safety rules. Knowing and following these rules is key to preventing serious injury while working on scaffolding systems.

Note potential hazards

Constant vigilance is vital when working at height, and it's important to inspect the area and equipment for potential hazards. The work area, tools, and scaffolding structure itself all need to be examined at frequent intervals to prevent hazards from going unnoticed.

Also, any time a change in the work area or scaffolding occurs, the structure should be reexamined.

Oversight from a competent person

Any time you build, move, or dismantle a scaffold, you need to have a competent person present to supervise the process. This person should perform daily inspections to check for flaws, hazards, or other issues.

Install proper guards

Guard rails, toe boards, barricades, and other guards can prevent falls or injuries from falling objects. Note that ladders or stairs should also be installed and that rails or poles are not to be used to ascend or descend the structure.

Respect load limits

Scaffolding designs and materials should account for the types of materials and equipment that will be present on the structure. Bringing too much weight onto a given platform can cause it to collapse.

Use consistent parts

When constructing a scaffold, use components that are specifically designed to be compatible. Mixing and matching parts from different manufacturers or those that are built for different loads can compromise the entire structure, leading to a collapse and/or injury.

Scaffolding Safety By Industry

Each industry has unique hazards, and thus specific safety protocols should be followed when using scaffolding in the following areas.

Commercial

Commercial construction scaffolds are used to assist with construction processes, and therefore, heavy materials are typically present.

Tips for commercial construction applications include:

- Always wear personal protective equipment (PPE) in and around work areas.
- Take special care with heavy materials and tools. Get help lifting heavy loads or use hoisting equipment when needed.
- Mind where heavy equipment is placed. Give scaffolding plenty of clearance.
- Clear materials and tools from the scaffolding at the end of each shift.
- Follow all directions from supervisors as well as OSHA regulations.

Industrial

Industrial scaffolds used in manufacturing and maintenance need to follow certain standards. Special safety precautions are also advised.

- Avoid the use of shore or lean-to scaffolds.
- Use proper lockout-tagout procedures when using scaffolding to access equipment.

- Wear PPE at all times.
- Build scaffolds, including decks and platforms, for durability and skid resistance.

Shipyards

Scaffolds used for shipyard staging need to be able to withstand the atmosphere present near water.

- Build scaffolds from materials that will withstand exposure to seawater and the elements.
- Inspect scaffolds regularly to keep them in top condition.
- Take special care with front edge distance.
- Handle heavy materials with caution, since marine hanging staging isn't usually designed to withstand heavy loads.

Government

Scaffolding used in renovations or construction of government buildings must adhere to high standards of safety.

- Follow OSHA safety standards for scaffolds.
- Always wear adequate PPE at all times on job sites.
- Build scaffolds for the loads they'll have to bear.

Importance Of Training In Scaffolding Safety

One final tip for scaffolding safety is to make sure everyone is fully trained. Having a qualified person on-site will see to it that personnel are thoroughly trained in scaffolding safety before any work begins.

At Scaffolding Solutions, we pride ourselves on offering the highest quality scaffolding products and superior safety standards. Our team is comprised of fully trained members in varying levels of scaffolding safety. Each of our scaffolds uses high-quality products and adheres to all OSHA safety standards.

With regular training and instruction being performed, plus updates to training every time circumstances change, your employees are at a lower risk of injury.

Scaffolding Safety

At Scaffolding Solutions, we believe that there are no shortcuts to safety. Our company integrates safety into each employee's job requirements and we hold our employees to the highest standards. All of our scaffolding platforms are built to the highest level of security. This ensures that your employees and contractors are safe during their work shift.

If your business needs erecting and/or dismantling, consider working with a qualified person to get the job done right. Our team members are capable of identifying existing and predictable hazards of scaffolds and quickly removing dangers before problems arise.

Continue reading to learn more about our safety standards and the types of scaffolding we erect.

Focus On Scaffolding Safety

From start to finish our company will be with you every step of the way. We can suggest the best type of working platform for your job based on maximum intended loads, weather, and working hours.

Scaffolding Solutions takes extra precaution to make sure that each worker is kept safe while on the job site. We always provide the option for additional protective systems, such as:

- Overhead protection tunnels to reduce falling object hazards
- Jobsite containment
- Safety netting
- Confined space rescue teams
- Personal fall arrest systems

Scaffolding Solutions also takes the time to educate workers on the proper protocol and safety requirements of working on scaffolding. We will inform the crews of our safety tags and what signs to look out for should something go wrong.

Our employees can promptly provide corrective measures to eliminate hazards on your scaffolds. If there are any problems with fall damage or conditions that are unsanitary, our team will work quickly to resolve it.

OCTO® Scaffolding System Is Safer

The OCTO® scaffolding equipment we use is safer and more versatile than most other scaffolding equipment available. Strength, safety and stability are achieved using a few well-balanced lightweight components connected vertically and horizontally with unique patented connectors.

All components are secured and will never loosen unintentionally through vibrations, etc. OCTO® scaffolding equipment not only gives the scaffold stability and strength but also allows it to follow the most “impossible” facades without dangerous “gaps” in the structure.

Extensively Trained & Highly Qualified Team Members

When you choose Scaffolding Solutions, you will work directly with highly-trained members of our team. Each of our employees undergoes rigorous job-safety training that involves basic scaffolding erection and safety techniques. Employees also receive first aid, CPR, and bloodborne pathogen training.

The team at Scaffolding Solutions can securely erect scaffolding and work with you to ensure that your crew members are safe. We want to see to it that your job site is fully secure by reducing the risk of hazards before they arise.

Adhering To Scaffolding Standards On Every Job Site

At Scaffolding Solutions, we want your work site to be safe, and that can start with the safe use of scaffolding. Having properly installed and erected scaffolding with trained employees can save you money and protect you against potential legal action.

Each of our scaffolds uses high-quality products and adheres to all OSHA safety standards. Our company erects scaffolding that includes toeboards, debris nets, and safety tags. We fully inspect the scaffolds to guarantee that they are within federal safety regulations. Scaffolds are made of weather-resistant, treated wood and are protected from updraft and wind uplift.

Training Employees & Contractors On Safe Use Of Scaffolding

After we erect a scaffold, we work directly with the job site crew to train them on proper scaffolding protocol. We will provide your contractors and employees with a thorough rundown of scaffolding safety.

We have a dedicated Risk Manager that is always thinking one step ahead. The Risk Manager has the authorization to take prompt corrective measures should any hazards arise. This ensures that all workers are safe while working on the scaffolding.

Our Risk Management team will make sure that your site is up to OSHA scaffolding standards before we leave a job site. Keeping your workforce safe is critical, while quality construction and education of scaffolding usage is a top priority.

Learn More From Our Scaffolding Safety Guide

Our company always strives to match our customer's needs. We have successfully erected scaffolding for large and small businesses, government buildings, and residential projects alike. When you work with Scaffolding Solutions, you can be confident that you and your employees' safety is forefront in our minds.

To learn more about our safety standards and training, read through our scaffolding safety guide. You can also contact Scaffolding Solutions if you have any questions about erecting or dismantling a scaffold for your job site.